

Clarity Breeds Clarity

The disparity between recruiters and candidates, and what a two-line fix looks like

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I recently spent time applying for roles I am genuinely qualified for.

The CV I wrote myself, with real examples, honest language, and 25 years of traceable experience, was rejected before a human ever read it.

The version that passed screening was keyword-dense, example-light, and written by a tool that has never held a job, managed a crisis, or stood in front of a lending committee.

I did not write this post to complain about that. I wrote it because I recognised the pattern, and patterns that are understood can be fixed.

THE PATTERN

Recruiters and candidates are experiencing the same broken process from opposite ends and blaming each other for the symptoms of a problem neither of them designed.

What recruiters say: Too many unqualified applicants. Candidates don't read the spec. Interview quality has dropped. AI CVs are flooding the inbox.

What candidates say: 100 applications. 2 responses. I matched every requirement. My honest CV was rejected. The AI one passed.

Neither group is wrong. Both are describing symptoms. The cause is the tool sitting between them, the one that was adopted to solve a volume problem and is now being mistaken for a quality filter.

THE DUMMY CAKE

You have seen those display cakes in a bakery window. Beautiful icing. Perfect layers. Wouldn't feed a sparrow. There is a polystyrene form underneath. It was never real cake.

A keyword-dense, AI-generated CV with zero demonstrated examples of skill use is a dummy cake. It passes ATS screening beautifully. It tells you almost nothing about the person attached to it. The system rewards the icing, not the recipe. And right now, the bakery is full of them, because candidates responded rationally to the incentive the system created.

THE MODEL, WHERE THE PROCESS BREAKS

This is not a complaint. It is a funnel problem. Funnel problems have a root cause. Root causes have fixes.

Current process:

100 applications, ATS scores and ranks, recruiter interviews top scorers, hire

Failure point:

ATS was designed to reduce volume. It was never designed to assess competence. It does the first job efficiently, including filtering out your best candidates if they wrote their own CV honestly.

Proposed two-layer process:

- AI/ATS screens 100, shortlists 20, let the tool do the job it was built for.
- Recruiter requests authentic CV from the 20, screens to 8, human reads human
- Interview the 8, conversation, not first contact!

The recruiter gets fewer applications to read, and better matched ones. The candidate gets a fair read from a person, not a parser. The interview is reserved for people who actually deserve to be in the room.

THE ONE-LINE FIX

Recruiters are people too. Most did not choose ATS, it was handed to them as a solution to drowning in volume. They were not shown what happens under the hood. They were not shown the dummy cake problem from the candidate's side of the process.

They are not the enemy. They are the other end of the same broken funnel.

The smallest possible ask:

"This role uses ATS / AI screening in the first round."

One line. Added to the job posting. Candidates calibrate. The system functions as it was intended to. The ethical question disappears. The person who actually fits your role stops being filtered out by an algorithm that cannot read context.

I have spent 25 years walking into businesses, reading the systems they run on, finding where the process breaks, and proposing fixes that work for both sides of the problem.

This is the same thing. Different subject.

Clarity breeds clarity. The gap between recruiters and candidates is not a personality conflict. It is a communication gap with a middleware problem in the middle. And communication gaps close when both sides can see the same funnel.

The full breakdown, disparity table, funnel comparison, dummy cake analysis, is in the attached Excel file. Two CVs are attached as well, one written for a human reader, one optimised for ATS. Same person. Completely different read. That is also the point.

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